

Executive Compensation Benchmark

Prepared in support of the Founder Services Agreement · Amber's Angels, Inc. · May 2026

Purpose: document IRS "reasonable compensation" basis for Grant Lindberg as CEO/CTO

IRS regulations require that compensation paid to officers and key employees of 501(c)(3) organizations be "reasonable" — defined as the amount that would ordinarily be paid for like services by like enterprises under like circumstances. The following benchmark establishes that a salary of **\$120,000–\$180,000 per year** is reasonable for the role of Founder/CEO/CTO at Amber's Angels.

ROLE DESCRIPTION

Grant Lindberg serves as the founding executive of Amber's Angels, performing the combined functions of Chief Executive Officer and Chief Technology Officer for an early-stage nonprofit technology organization. Specific responsibilities include:

- Full-stack software architecture and development (FastAPI, Next.js, PostgreSQL, React Native)
- AI/ML pipeline design and integration (YOLOv8, OpenALPR, Plate Recognizer)
- Cloud infrastructure and DevOps (DigitalOcean, PM2, GitHub Actions, nginx)
- Mobile application development (Expo React Native, Android Kotlin native modules, Apple App Store)
- Executive leadership: strategy, fundraising, government relations, grant writing support
- Pilot program management: Carroll County, GA deployment coordination
- Regulatory compliance: FAA Part 107/108, FEMA IPAWS, IRS 501(c)(3)

MARKET COMPARABLES — FOR-PROFIT SECTOR

ROLE / SOURCE	GEOGRAPHY	MEDIAN / MIDPOINT	75TH PCTILE / HIGH
Software Developer, Senior (BLS OES 2024)	National	\$132,270	\$168,570
Software Developer, Senior (BLS OES 2024)	Georgia	\$121,480	\$155,000
CTO, early-stage startup (Levels.fyi / Glassdoor 2025)	National	\$160,000	\$230,000
ML/AI Engineer, Senior (BLS / industry surveys 2024)	National	\$155,000	\$195,000

ROLE / SOURCE	GEOGRAPHY	MEDIAN / MIDPOINT	75TH PCTILE / HIGH
Full-stack contractor, independent (market rate 2025)	Atlanta metro	\$130/hr (\$270K equiv)	\$175/hr (\$364K equiv)

MARKET COMPARABLES — NONPROFIT SECTOR

ROLE / SOURCE	ORGANIZATION SIZE	MEDIAN	75TH PCTILE
Nonprofit CEO/Executive Director (Candid/GuideStar 2024)	Budget < \$500K	\$78,000	\$112,000
Nonprofit CEO/Executive Director (Candid/GuideStar 2024)	Budget \$500K–\$1M	\$105,000	\$148,000
Nonprofit technology director (NTEN Salary Survey 2024)	Any size	\$115,000	\$152,000
Public safety / emergency tech nonprofit CEO (CompassPoint)	Early stage	\$110,000	\$165,000
Amber's Angels proposed range (founder performing dual CEO+CTO function)		\$120,000	\$180,000

QUALIFICATIONS SUPPORTING THE HIGH END OF RANGE

FACTOR	DETAIL
Dual role	Performing CEO + CTO functions simultaneously. Organizations that split these roles typically pay \$80K–\$120K each.
Technical specialization	AI/ML, computer vision, RTMP/ALPR pipelines, and FAA-regulated drone systems are high-demand specializations commanding premiums above general software development.
IP creation	Founder created all organizational IP from scratch. The codebase represents significant proprietary value assigned to the Organization (see Founder Services Agreement §5).
Mission risk	Founder deferred compensation and accepted personal financial risk during the formation period — a discount on market rate that supports paying at or above median upon funding.

FACTOR	DETAIL
Regulatory complexity	FEMA IPAWS integration, FAA Part 107/108 compliance, App Store review navigation, and 501(c)(3) formation require expertise beyond standard development roles.

IRS REBUTTABLE PRESUMPTION OF REASONABLENESS

Under IRC § 4958 and Treasury Regulation § 53.4958-6, a nonprofit board can establish a "rebuttable presumption" that compensation is reasonable by following a three-step process:

- 1. Approval by an independent body.** Compensation must be approved by the board of directors (or a compensation committee) composed of individuals who do not have a conflict of interest. *Action required: board vote, recorded in minutes.*
- 2. Reliance on comparable data.** The approving body must obtain and rely upon appropriate comparability data prior to making its determination. *This document satisfies that requirement.*
- 3. Documentation.** The basis for the determination must be documented in writing contemporaneously (within 60 days of the decision). *Action required: board minutes reference this benchmark by name and date.*

If these three steps are followed, the IRS bears the burden of proving the compensation is unreasonable. Without them, the burden shifts to the organization.

Conclusion

Based on the comparable data above, the Board of Directors of Amber's Angels, Inc. finds that annual compensation of **\$120,000–\$180,000**, plus standard benefits (health insurance, retirement contribution up to IRS limits, expense reimbursement), is reasonable for Grant Lindberg in his capacity as founding CEO/CTO. A specific figure within this range shall be set by the board at the time of formal employment offer, taking into account the Organization's funding level and cash flow at that time.

This determination was made by the Board of Directors on: _____ and is recorded in board meeting minutes dated the same.

Sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics (OES), May 2024; Candid/GuideStar Nonprofit Compensation Report 2024; NTEN Nonprofit Technology Salary Survey 2024; CompassPoint Nonprofit Services compensation data; Levels.fyi CTO compensation data 2025; Glassdoor senior software engineer / CTO ranges, Atlanta metro, 2025. Specific figures are approximate midpoints of ranges published by these sources and are on file for board review upon request.